

Marriage

What God instituted in the beginning — a study in Genesis 1 and 2

Introduction: Going Back to Scripture

There is a common saying that the man is supposed to be an authoritarian. Rather than argue from opinion, we should go to Scripture and see what God Himself describes.

When the Pharisees came to Jesus with their questions about marriage, He pointed them back to Genesis, to see what God originally instituted (Matthew 19:3–6).

1. Humanity Created and Given a Mandate — Genesis 1:26–28

Scripture says, “*Let us make man in our image.*” The passage later points to the fact that it was **male and female** that God actually planned to create.

- The woman is not a second derivative or an afterthought. It was man **and** woman that God intended to create from the beginning.
- God did not bless the man only; He blessed the man **and** the woman.
- He said to them, “*Be fruitful and multiply, fill the earth and subdue it.*”

So when it comes to purpose — the topic of the man and the woman — Scripture is telling us about the female **and** the male, not just the man. You should not see the woman as second in authority or as a second derivative.

2. The Origin Story in Detail — Genesis 2:7–17

Genesis 1 gives us the summary; Genesis 2 goes in depth into the same origin story.

- **Verse 7** — the LORD God **formed** the man from the dust of the ground.
- **Verse 15** — God **placed** the man in the garden to tend it and keep it.
- **Verses 16–17** — God gave the man a **commandment** and a **mandate** to follow.

In Matthew 19 there was confusion about marriage, and Jesus’ answer was essentially, “*Go back to Genesis and see how God intended it.*” So do not feel lost or wonder why we are going through this process. Genesis shows us the pattern: the man was formed, the man was placed, and the man was given a commandment.

3. “It Is Not Good for the Man to Be Alone” — Genesis 2:18

Read verse 18: *“It is not good that man should be alone.”*

What does this mean? Is being alone a sin? Is it evil? Is it disgusting? At this point in the account, sin had not yet come into the world. So we should try to understand it by reading the previous verses.

Follow the refrain in Genesis 1:

- **Verse 18** — the lights were made to rule over the day and the night, and to divide the light from the darkness, *“and God saw that it was good.”*
- **Verse 21** — *“and God saw that it was good.”*
- **Verse 25** — God made the beasts of the earth, the best of the earth, *“and God saw that it was good.”*

Through the whole creation story, from day one to day six, God kept declaring, *“It is good.”* Then in Genesis 1:26–27, God created man in His own image; in verse 28, He blessed them. And in Genesis 1:31, *“God saw everything that He had made, and indeed it was very good.”*

So when God says in Genesis 2:18, *“It is not good,”* He is not saying that something is evil about the man, nor that everything else had suddenly become evil. What He means is that the man **alone** is functionally and structurally **incomplete** — in that state he is not able to fulfil the purpose God has given him.

Notice in Genesis 1:26–28 that God blessed **them** and said to **them** — them, them, them. God needed the pair for them to be fruitful, to multiply, and to subdue the earth.

4. Alone Is Not the Same as Lonely

The man should not be alone — that is, he should not remain in a state of isolation. But we must not confuse **being alone** with **being lonely**.

Adam was not lonely. He had the presence of God and he had the animals. He knew no deficiency, no need, and no unmet desire. Loneliness is not the same thing as being alone.

It is not because you feel lonely that God determines you need a counterpart. It is when you have been **formed**, and when you are **following God’s command**, that He says, *“It is not good for you to be alone; you need someone else.”*

And when other people are pairing up around you, that in itself does not mean you need to marry. Scripture says it is as you are walking in God’s purpose that you progress into the next thing.

5. Naming the Animals: God Creates the Desire — Genesis 2:19–20

Adam knew no desire and no need. So God brought the creatures to him to name them, and that exercise **placed a desire in his heart**. As he saw the animals in their pairs, a desire was created in him — an awareness that he lacked something.

The sequence of the naming is an act of **cognitive classification and authority**. Adam, possessing immense intellect, defined the nature of every creature. He could say, *“This kind of animal is not of my nature.”* He had the ability to declare that this animal is, or is not, a counterpart to him. He must have seen every creature — even the chimpanzee, the nearest thing to him in appearance — and concluded that none of them was of his kind. That would have created in him a burning desire.

So in Genesis 2:18–22, it is not Adam’s desire that makes him go searching for the woman. It is God who says, *“I will make him a helper comparable to him,”* and it is God who brings the woman to him afterwards.

When you see couples going about, it is not that desire which should push you to marry, but the fact that God has said you should not be alone.

Why the delay?

You might wonder: was the naming unsuccessful? Was it only a device to make him desire? No — it was to make him feel his need and his limitation, so that he would know he could not do this for himself. Adam could have played with the animals; he could have enjoyed them. But when God finally did it for him, Adam was filled with **gratitude**. God showed him every creature so that he would feel the need, and so that when the woman was brought to him he would be filled with thanksgiving.

6. “A Helper” Does Not Mean “A Subordinate” — Genesis 2:18

There is a saying that “helper” means subordinate, but that is wrong.

The Hebrew word used of the woman is **ezer**. The same word is used in Psalm 121:1–2: *“I will lift up my eyes to the hills — from whence comes my help? My help comes from the LORD.”* There, **ezer** describes God Himself, and it carries the sense of **indispensable, life-saving strength**, a **critical need met**, a **sustainer** of the person.

So it does not mean she is a subordinate. It means she is the indispensable, life-saving strength of the man. That is what it means to be *“a helper comparable to him”* — like a magnet, two opposite poles that belong together.

7. The Woman Brought to the Man — Genesis 2:21–24

Adam did not go out to look for the woman; **she was brought to him**, so that the man could never claim he had a hand in her creation. And the rib was taken:

*The woman was not taken from the head to rule over the man,
nor from the foot for the man to trample upon her,
but out of his side, to be **equal** with him;
under his arm, to be **protected** by him;
near his heart, to be **loved** by him.*

The woman is your strength, and someone you should love.

Verse 23. After the desire had been placed in the man — not by what other people were saying, but by God Himself — Adam saw the woman and said, “*This is now bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh.*” You can feel the relief in it: *finally, God has done it.* For all his superior intellect, he had classified every creature and found none like himself. At last he saw the woman and said, “*This is the one.*” The desire produced so much gratitude that he prophesied over her: this is co-man, a co-labourer in God’s purpose.

Verse 24. “*Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and they shall become one flesh.*” This is God instituting marriage. The man was formed, and he was given a task. Marriage is not defined by what the world says, but by what Scripture has said.

End of lesson notes.